

Yeddy Go STEADY

The crisis in the state BJP blows over as a fragile peace worked out by the high command clips Yeddyurappa's powers considerably. It's advantage Reddys now.

By Stephen David

When large parts of Karnataka were ravaged by floods last month, the BJP Government should have been busy in disaster management and relief work. Instead, as a flood of dissent swelled within the party, its leaders were busy trying to contain the fratricide that may have left an indelible mark for Karnataka Chief Minister B.S. Yeddyurappa. After days of bickering, the party High Command has worked out a truce, but one that is heavily loaded in favour of the mining brothers from Bellary—state Tourism Minister G. Janardhan Reddy, Revenue Minister G. Karunkara Reddy, youngest brother Somashekhara Reddy—and Health Minister B. Sriramulu, a family friend considered one of the brothers. Little surprise then that Yeddyurappa is running from the Vaishno Devi shrine to the MM Hills temple, seeking divine intervention.

Despite the slew of concessions granted to the Reddy brothers, (see box), Yeddyurappa realises that his old foes are very much active. Last week, scores of MLAs called upon Bangalore

South MP H.N. Ananth Kumar, who harbours ambitions of becoming chief minister. His inclusion in the core committee to oversee the first BJP Government south of the Vindhyas is resented by a helpless Yeddyurappa. The newfound bonhomie among the rebel group has only raised the chief minister's blood pressure and sugar as he had had to be administered extra insulin. His stress levels though, are unlikely to come down any time soon.

The biggest setback for him has been the dwindling number of diehard supporters. Some ministers that he hoped would stick by his side during his time of crisis were simply not around when he needed them the most. Others who stood by him through thick and

thin had to be shown the door as part of the compromise. Certain private meetings—like the one with Janardhan and Sriramulu held at his Dollar Colony residence late November 9 night—have taken the wind out of Yeddyurappa who till recently looked unassailable after he led the BJP to victory in seven of the 13 by-elections, converting his minority Government into one with a legitimate majority.

Yet others, like his friend-turned-Reddy supporter Honnali MLA M.P. Renukacharya—who regularly briefed the media in the Hyderabad hotel where 40-odd MLAs were holed up for 11 days till they returned to Bangalore on November 9—he may have to soon see at cabinet meetings. During the crisis, the Bangalore Police had been tasked to arrest Renukacharya over a non-bailable warrant relating to a 2007 case. The additional chief metropolitan magistrate is expecting the police to produce the MLA before him by November 17. Whether it will happen is anybody's guess. In August, state BJP unit chief D.V. Sadananda Gowda had issued a showcause notice to Renukacharya over party indiscipline. But even at that time his fellow BJP MLAs like Belur Gopalakrishna, chairman of the Assurances Committee and another promi-

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